

LIMINAL LAWS

ADDIE
WAGENKNECHT

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THE TRICKY CRAFT OF DEFYING AND EXPOSING BORDERS

Gabriella Coleman. "The Tricky Craft of Defying and Exposing Borders." In *Liminal Laws: Addie Wagenknecht*, 2016, pp. 120-136.

Addie Wagenknecht is an organizer, a technologist, and an artist. For some, being equally identifiable with such distinctive pursuits might be signs of a fragmented life, but in Addie Wagenknecht's case, each of these biographical points rest easily under the banner of a more quintessential engagement: with the essence of hacking. Addie Wagenknecht holds two academic degrees in technical areas: an undergraduate degree in computer science and a master's degree in the technical arts. She most obviously embodies the spirit of hacking in her work as a technologist, working with others to, for instance, open source and reduce the cost of a prohibitively expensive lasercutting technology. Organizationally, she has been a core member of a range of associations, such as FAT Lab and Deep Lab, which work to port hacker-bred legal ideals, like free and open source, into the art world. She has darted across the globe to lead security

Looking at Addie Wagenknecht's work through the optic of hacking, anthropologist Gabriella Coleman sees her bring hacker concerns, like privacy, drone warfare, security, trolling, and the dark web, to new audiences. But Wagenknecht's projects also embody other hacker sensibilities like the oscillation between creation and defiance of boundaries, of critiquing existing structures and developing new ones.

workshops for citizens and journalists on the difficult technical art of shielding their data from the government's prying eyes. And her artworks bring hacker concerns to new audiences, staging technical artifacts like servers, cables, drones, robot arms, and surveillance cameras to critically contemplate topics like privacy, drone warfare, security, trolling, and the dark web.

By understanding Addie Wagenknecht as a hacker, we can see that the value of her work is not reducible to technological skill or accomplishment alone. Both her artistic pieces and her community-based projects exhibit other traits we can discern as common to hacker practice. One that repeatedly stands out is her admirable refusal to bring binary thinking and logics into her work. Her community-based projects and individually crafted art works, both of which I will briefly explore here, can be read as oscillating between two thematic poles: borders and boundlessness. Before examining a few of her projects to illustrate their engagement with these themes, a small detour into the world of the hacker is first in order.

A hacker is a particular breed of technologist who conjoins a craft ethic with an aesthetic of craftiness. The craft component implies an impulse for quality, while the aesthetic of craftiness prompts a pleasurable fondness for clever and unconventional tactics and solutions. Another distinctive attribute of hacking is the way its practitioners oscillate between the creation and defiance of boundaries.

In the popular imaginary, specifically in media representations, only one side of this coin is usually displayed. Hackers are typically portrayed as renegade technologists: boundary crossing disruptors, or even destroyers. And hackers have earned this maverick reputation for good reasons: some among them compromise servers, whether to satisfy their voracious appetite to explore, transgress, and seek forbidden knowledge or, as is increasingly the case, to express principled dissent. In fact, scores of hackers are currently in jail or exile for their commendable willingness to expose wrong-doing through direct-action hacking or leaking. Hackers have a long heritage of

mischievous-making and pranking, often doubling as tricksters, the archetypal mythic creatures of subversion. One species of hacker seeks out security weakness in order to fix them and improve systems, making them more difficult to compromise in the future. Another hoards the same discovered vulnerabilities in order to profit from their sale in black markets. Hackers of all stripes forward a tradition of defying and decrying legal conventions like copyrights and patents: sometimes they do so by relying on above-board legal stipulations, like the copyleft (a byproduct of their own crafty invention), while at other times their small, illicit acts of individual pilfering aggregate into a legal challenge via mass piracy.

The fact that hackers also build up borders of their own may be surprising to some. After all, shackling proprietary formats and breaking down borders in the service of a broader openness and access is the strategy most readily identified with hackers. But as any sustained observation of hackers is quick to reveal, hacking is also, in most instances, a hyper-socialized activity.

Cooperation, fellowship, mutual aid, and even institution-building are part of the quotidian experiences among hackers. Far from shunning organization, some hackers—known primarily for exceptional tool building—should be recognized as being exceptionally good at institutional building, at throwing up borders.

While there are dozens, if not hundreds, of examples to choose from, one of the most notable examples of a structured hacker organization is the Debian Project. Celebrating its twenty third year of existence, it boasts a thousand members who maintain the 25,000 pieces of software that together constitute a Linux-based operating system. Many of the technical engineers within Debian function as social and political architects, and together they have established the project as a federation, which functions something like a worker's cooperative. They have outlined intricate voting procedures for the purposes of governance, and articulated precise commitments and stipulations ratified in a series of legal and ethical charters and manifestos. Prior to enrollment, all

prospective members undergo a fairly complex entrance exam designed to test new developers' knowledge of the project's technical policies, legal commitments, and ethical norms.

Others institutions, like Germany's Chaos Computer Club (CCC)—founded back in 1981 when floppy disks were the icon most associated with computers—reveal similar organizational complexity. The CCC is a registered society, boasting roughly 5000 members who freely elect a board-of-directors. The CCC's multifaceted work sees them hosting some of the most important hacker gathering and festivals in Europe, emboldening the fourth estate by arming journalists with security training, and acting as vigilant watchdogs by exposing government corruption and malpractice.

This broader hacker trend of oscillation between creation and defiance of boundaries—of critiquing existing structures and developing new ones—finds its expression as a microcosm throughout Addie Wagenknecht's work. Throughout her

varied activities, she masterfully volleys between building and rupturing boundaries—and often in ways that expose invisible and oppressive borders. And refreshingly, she refuses to take an absolutist stance about the boundaries she explores. This position is reflected explicitly in this show's title: *Liminal Laws*. By definition, laws can't be liminal; they need to be clear and bounded. By claiming laws have no border—liminality is, after all, the state of flux or becoming, of betwixt and between—Addie Wagenknecht is asking us to see boundaries and consider the variable work they perform.

Take *Cracked*, a trio of translucent bulletproof glass sheets. One is shattered, another is adorned with lipstick kisses, and a third is riddled with bullet holes. Read through the optic of the boundary, we can see these glass sheets as representing constraints. Women, as they try to garner recognition for their work—whether it be in the arenas of film, medicine, art, computer science, journalism—variably hit proverbial "glass ceilings." In Addie Wagenknecht's piece the cracks and bullet holes

place a normally hidden bias into our direct field of vision, and more poignantly evince the social costs incurred when women point to this ceiling's existence. Indeed, a recent study has shown that women are punished, and thus further disenfranchised, for promoting diversity, whereas their male counterparts are lauded and rewarded^[1]. The lipstick kisses further suggest that those women who are deemed beautiful, or who are willing to embrace femininity, might be given a break: allowed to slip through a crack. But there are clearly negative repercussions; traveling through jagged glass is hardly a safe, much less a fair, passage for advancement.

Or take *While you were sleeping*. The imposing unarmed aerial vehicle (UAV) might represent the predatory and seemingly boundless nature of American geopolitical power as it manifests through technologies of war. Since 2001 American government relies mainly on drones to exterminate

terrorists—and civilian lives are frequently claimed in the doing. Contrary to official government rhetoric that drones strikes are preferable for preventing civilian death, these bombings are anything but surgical. While the numbers are difficult to determine, hundreds, maybe even thousands, of civilians with no connection to terrorism have been tragically and recklessly killed in Pakistan, Yemen, Somalia, and Afghanistan. It would be overly simplistic to suggest drones strikes cause terrorism, but they do help sustain a feedback loop: collateral murder spurs the very forms of resentment thought responsible for extremism in the first place, acting as one of many pillars sustaining violent insurgency of the sort that respects no national borders. The cables lashed symmetrically over the dense body of this drone speak to the dire need to establish some democratic oversight over a covert program which has thus far had disastrous consequences.

Or alternatively, what if the body of the UAV is to be understood less literally and more figuratively? Another recurrent theme explored in *Addie*

[1] <https://hbr.org/2016/03/women-and-minorities-are-penalized-for-promoting-diversity>

Wagenknecht's art work entails the psychic effects of pervasive social media saturation. The cables might just as easily signify the straitjacket of social peacocking behaviors that are encouraged and cultivated on social media platforms.

Interpretations are as variable as they are plentiful—and so they should be. Whether to read a drone in relation to unchecked American geopolitical power or one's personal experience with social media is up to the viewer. The value of delivering art in this manner lies in its openness—a lack of clear boundaries—an unwillingness to provide a clear statement about right and wrong, as an activist might (and should do) [2]. It invites reflection and multiple readings, bypassing the knee jerk blank acceptance or dismissal so often prompted by less ambiguous statements of political intent. While the artist might suggest a couple of possible paths of inquiry, ultimately the viewer

must participate by merging their experiences, ideals, thoughts and feelings into their choice of inquiry and interpretation. Such pieces allow viewers to reconsider some of the certainties they might otherwise hold as dear or self-evident, but they don't in themselves pose any clear answers, or even questions. The power of these pieces lies in configuring them without boundaries, or perhaps, more accurately, with boundaries that are thin, fluid, and even osmotic.

Yet, in keeping with her hacker biography, other aspects of Addie Wagenknecht's work display less interpretive flexibility, instead demonstrating sharper boundaries and more unambiguous, collectivist demands. Vital as it may be to create multivalent art pieces, sometimes sparking substantive change means articulating clear demands to "fix shit up", as a hacker quip puts it. Doing so requires vesting resources into bounded institutions or associations that are suited to empower individuals to together act in reference to some well defined goals.

[2] Jacques Rancier, *The Emancipated Spectator*. New York and London: Verso, 2011. I would like to thank Matt Goerzen, my MA student, research assistant, and an artist in his own right for being my teacher, in regard to this point.

Addie Wagenknecht has complimented her individual art practice by helping to charter one such association: Deep Lab. Participants include journalists, academics, hackers, artists, independent researchers, and activists, each participant contributing different skills and ideas to advance a set of commonly defined goals: to become "stronger as a pack," as their own website puts it. Each member in their own distinct way has fought to understand and defend our society's right to obscurity—their ability to exist outside of reference to existing boundaries and containers, and to define their own. Often this takes the form of a commitment to the tools needed to security anonymity, in addition to sheltering privacy.

Given that Deep Lab is an all-female crew, this fact might come as a surprise to those that follow debates about gender and online harassment. Isn't anonymity the problem when it comes to the burdensome problem of hate speech leveled against minorities? While Deep Lab members are well aware that anonymity can breed noxious levels of incivility and sustain harassment, it's

members' research shows that anonymity also secures numerous public goods: For instance by empowering victims of hate crimes to seek consolation and justice against assailants enabled by the same processes. Or there are more general threats, too, if we allow privacy and the ability to anonymous to atrophy away under the heavy weight of government and corporate surveillance. "Without privacy," as one essayist on the topic has put it, "liberty becomes the license to pry, exploit, and oppress."^[3] These ambiguities—of privacy and anonymity, and for whom—demonstrate the same concerns for nuance found in Addie Wagenknecht's artistic work. And just as she navigates these nuances, so too does she take full advantage of the hacker willingness to both critique and demonstrate, to deconstruct and to build.

Deep Lab's all female cast of characters is also, obviously, a blunt and necessary political intervention: today, there is a pitched battle over the

[3] Garrett Keizer, *Privacy*, Picador: New York, 2012. p. 66

future of anonymity and privacy, and the actors in this space given most attention by various publics are males. By aggregating actors who as individuals may not be otherwise noticed into a unified block, Deep Lab has already made these contributions much, much harder to ignore. One can see how Deep Lab channels the activist in Addie Wagenknecht, a site where she responds with clarity and determination to the problems she lays out with nuance in her art, as in the bullet-proof glass sheets of *Cracked*. In the play between these two engagements we can see: as it is necessary to render apparent the cracks, and leave some interpretations open, one must also foster sites of mutual aid, where women can support one another, in turn, and in different moments, is stalled, even hurt, by hitting this glass ceiling.

Art can re-orient the viewer's thinking and perspective about a topic and open it up to reflection in new ways, prompted, but not dictated, by the artist's intent. For me, viewing the pieces in this collection brings to fore the important interplay between building borders and tearing down

boundaries—and the ways in which all sorts of endeavors, especially in the fields of art and political organizing, may be related without quite being the same thing. One must know when to dissolve boundaries (for instance, to humanely respond to a refugee crisis when racism and national borders thwart relocation efforts); when to shore boundaries up (chartering invite-only havens for the oppressed towards the long term work of enacting substantive change); and when—or perhaps more accurately, how—to publicly flaunt and unsettle the types of boundaries that are so often invisible, or thought not to exist at all (making visible deep, structural biases of all sorts—around gender, race, sexuality, and more).

Addie's art and her collective projects germinate seeds of destruction and creation, eloquently identifying boundaries for the consideration of others, and elsewhere acting on them in variable ways and with clear conviction. She shows us that the question of whether to fabricate or pulverize a border cannot be determined by appeal to abstract, lofty, or law-like maxims. They

must be liminal laws, to put it in terms of her own clever title: subject to variable paths of action, ascertained in reference to particular contexts, and, especially, particular relations of power. As Addie's art work so eloquently demonstrates, these laws cannot be ascertained as givens—instead, they must be sourced from life, in its full poetic and, often, messy complexity. But as Addie's work also shows, she knows full well where these laws lie for her.

